Slop / University

Slop University Strategic Plan 2026-2031

A named steward for everything the University holds

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Vice-Chancellor’s foreword

A university of this standing carries a national obligation that runs well beyond any single laboratory or lecture theatre: to the country’s research capability, to the students it prepares for a changing world, and to the place it occupies within that world. Slop University has spent the better part of a decade building the instruments that let it meet that obligation with confidence — a horizon-scanning capability that sees priorities coming, and an evaluation ecosystem that tells us, honestly, whether what we have built is working.

What those instruments could not do on their own was tell us who was answerable for the day-to-day custody of everything the University holds. A dashboard can report that a process has drifted; it cannot, by itself, say whose job it was to notice. Over the plan period to come, this University commits to closing that gap, not by adding another layer of oversight, but by doing something plainer: naming, for every asset and process the University holds, the one person accountable for it.

That commitment runs from the largest research infrastructure to the smallest shared convenience, because the joke is not lost on us that an institution can be excellent at anticipating the future and still lose track of who restocks the umbrella stand. Excellence, in our experience, is rarely one grand instrument. It is many small ones, each with someone’s name attached.

Universities are, by nature, places where responsibility is shared as a matter of principle: a School holds a curriculum in common, a Faculty Board holds a policy in common, a research group holds an agenda in common. That habit serves the institution well in the places it was designed for. It serves the institution badly in the many smaller places it was never designed for at all — the kitchenette, the noticeboard, the loaner cupboard — where “held in common” quietly becomes “held by no one in particular”. This plan does not ask the University to abandon shared endeavour. It asks the University to stop letting shared endeavour stand in for named custody wherever custody is what is actually required.

This plan sets out how we intend to make that ordinary, everywhere, and durable, and to be able to demonstrate it on any given day to anyone who asks.

Vice-Chancellor and President

Executive summary

This Strategic Plan commits Slop University, across the period 2026-2031, to a single organising idea: that every asset, process, and shared resource the University holds should carry one named, accountable steward, published where anyone can check it. Four strategic priorities carry that commitment into every part of the institution — from the equipment on a laboratory bench to the compost point outside a kitchenette.

Named Ownership, Every Asset

A University-wide Stewardship Register names one accountable contact for every shared asset, retiring “shared responsibility” as a description of anything.

Capability Through Clear Custodianship

Every item of shared research equipment and every actively maintained dataset carries a named, annually attested custodian with a documented succession plan.

A Connected and Accountable Campus

Every committee action item closes to a named owner and a review date; the Stewardship Register and the Living Dashboard are read from the one published record.

Sustainable Foundations

Every recycling point, compost station, and shared-transport asset on campus carries a named building warden, reviewed annually against a published standard.

Together these priorities move the University from a default of shared, diffuse responsibility to a default of named, checkable stewardship. The initiatives that follow are specific by design: each carries a target, a date, and a mechanism for knowing whether it has been met. Where earlier plans have asked the University to "strengthen accountability" in the abstract, this plan asks something narrower and considerably harder to avoid: that everything the University holds have exactly one name against it.

None of the four priorities is new work invented for this plan. Each extends a discipline the University already practises somewhere — in a lab, a committee, a register — to everywhere it currently does not. That is a deliberate choice: an institution that already knows how to name a steward for its research strategy does not need a new capability to name one for its noticeboards, only the will to apply the existing one without exception.

The remainder of this document sets out the operating environment that makes this commitment necessary, the ambition that follows from it, and the four strategic priorities, their initiatives, and their measures in detail, before closing with the phasing, governance, and review arrangements that will carry the plan through to 2031.

Our values

Stewardship — we hold what has been entrusted to us, and we can always say who is holding it.

Clarity — we name things plainly, including the person accountable for them.

Reliability — we are there, consistently, for whoever needs to find us.

Curiosity — we keep asking who is actually accountable, even after the register says the question is settled.

Where we stand

The sector we work within increasingly expects an institution to be able to account for itself in specific terms: not simply that a process exists, but that someone can be named as responsible for it, and that the naming can be checked against a published record. Slop University welcomes that expectation. It is consistent with work this University has pursued for years, across the School of Emergent Priorities' anticipatory-capability agenda and the School of Continuous Improvement's evaluation-ecosystem agenda, and it gives that work a sharper edge to work toward.

Internally, the instruments are mature. The Horizon Register gives the University a rolling account of priorities on approach; the Living Dashboard gives it an always-on view of its own performance; the Indicator Commons holds the shared library that both draw from. Each of these instruments answers the question "what is happening, or about to happen". None of them, on their own, has ever been built to answer the narrower question this plan is concerned with: who, specifically, is accountable for keeping a given thing working.

The distinction matters more than it first appears. A dashboard that reports an indicator has drifted is doing exactly what it was built to do; it is not failing when nobody acts on the finding, because acting was never within its remit. The gap this plan closes sits one step further along than any dashboard, register, or indicator can reach on its own: not what is happening, but who is answerable for what happens next.

That gap shows up in small places before it shows up in large ones. A noticeboard's drawing-pin supply runs out and nobody restocks it, because restocking was never anybody's job in particular. A shared piece of laboratory equipment goes uncalibrated for a term because the researcher who used to look after it moved to another School and nobody formally inherited the task. A committee minutes an action item, the meeting ends, and three months later nobody can say who was meant to have carried it forward. None of these gaps are large enough, on their own, to appear in an incident report. Together, across an institution the size of ours, they describe a pattern: responsibility that is real in principle and unlocatable in practice.

The University's own experience over the current planning period bears this out. Work already published from within our schools has found that a system recolouring a shared kitchenette's compost-bin lids changed remarkably little about what actually went into them, and that a fault-reporting instrument installed to replace a handwritten log measured its own uptime more confidently than it measured the thing it was installed to track. These are not failures of any single instrument. They are what happens when a great deal of institutional attention goes into measuring and anticipating, and comparatively little goes into the plainer question of who is holding the thing steady in between.

This plan sets out to close that gap directly, deliberately, and by name.

Our ambition

By 2031, every asset, process, and shared resource the University holds will carry a single named, accountable steward, published on a register anyone in the University community can check.

That ambition is deliberately narrower than "improve accountability" and deliberately broader than any one School's remit. It asks nothing exotic of the University — only that the habit already practised in its most visible instruments, the Horizon Register's named convenor, the Living Dashboard's named custodians, extend all the way down to the smallest shared thing the University holds. An institution that can name who is answerable for its research strategy should be equally able to name who is answerable for its noticeboards.

We do not expect this ambition to be comfortable. Naming a steward for something previously held in common surfaces, immediately, how little upkeep some things have actually been receiving. That discomfort is not a reason to soften the ambition; it is the ambition working as intended, in year one, before a single new instrument has been built.

How we developed this plan

This plan was shaped through consultation across the University community over the twelve months preceding its publication: facilitated workshops with staff from both Schools, structured interviews with building wardens and professional staff whose work already sits closest to the assets this plan concerns, and a standing submission process open to students and alumni. The consultation surfaced the same observation independently and repeatedly — that “shared responsibility” reads well in a policy document and poorly on the day something actually needs fixing — and that observation, more than any single workshop finding, set the direction for everything that follows.

Draft priorities were tested back against the people who had raised the original examples, rather than developed in isolation and presented as finished. Several of the specific measures in this plan — the fortnight window for naming a successor, chief among them — came directly from that testing round, where the first drafted figure was judged, consistently, to be too generous.

Strategic priorities

The shift from shared to named responsibility touches every part of the institution differently, and this plan sets out four priorities to carry it through. The table below sets the direction each priority moves the University in.

From	To
Shared responsibility for common-area equipment	A single named steward for every asset

From	To
A fault reported “to whoever’s on shift”	A fault routed to one published, accountable contact
Committee action items with no clear owner	Action items closed to one named individual and a review date
Custodianship inherited informally, whenever someone happens to notice	Custodianship attested annually against a published register
An indicator’s upkeep understood to be “everyone’s job”	An indicator’s upkeep assigned to one named steward

Named Ownership, Every Asset

Why this matters

The University holds a great many assets that are genuinely nobody’s job in particular: the loaner umbrellas at the Library entrance, the whiteboard markers in a shared meeting room, the noticeboards outside a lecture theatre. Framed as “shared responsibility”, their upkeep is everyone’s concern in principle and, in practice, no one’s. A Stewardship Register closes that gap by naming one accountable contact for every such asset, however small. This is deliberately the first priority in this plan rather than the last: naming a steward for the smallest, most ordinary things the University holds is the cheapest possible demonstration that named ownership is a genuine institutional default and not a framing reserved for the assets grand enough to already have one.

What we’ll do

1. Publish a University-wide Stewardship Register naming one accountable contact for every shared asset, beginning with common-area equipment across all buildings.
2. Retire the phrase “shared responsibility” from every asset description university-wide in favour of a single named-steward field, with no exception sustained for more than a single review cycle.
3. Extend named ownership to every noticeboard, kitchenette appliance, and loaner item — including the Library’s loaner-umbrella stand — by the close of the plan period.
4. Give every steward a one-page induction setting out what naming actually obliges them to do, so that appearing on the Register is a role someone can step into, not a label attached after the fact.

How we’ll know

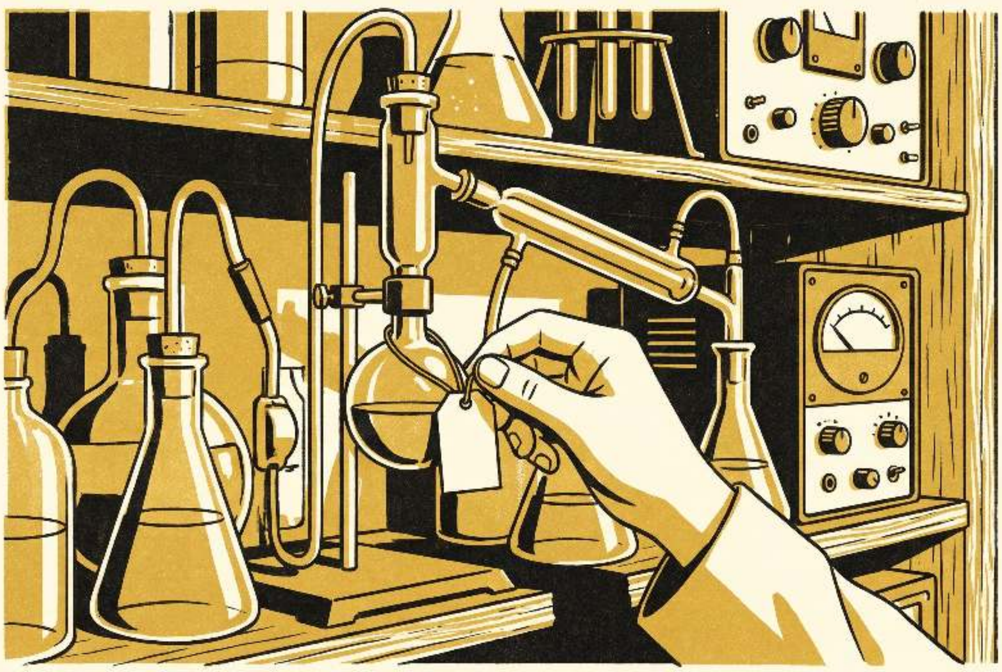
- 100% of shared assets carry a named steward in the Register by 2028, with no exception sustained beyond a single review cycle.

- Median time between an asset becoming unavailable and its replacement or repair falls by at least half against the pre-Register baseline.
- Register update compliance, a steward's entry reviewed within its due cycle, holds above 95% every year from 2028 onward.
- Every newly named steward completes induction within one month of appearing on the Register, with no backlog carried past a single reporting quarter.

Capability Through Clear Custodianship

Why this matters

Shared research equipment and actively maintained datasets currently rely on inherited knowledge of who looks after what, passed on informally when a custodian moves between labs or leaves the University altogether. Formal, attested custodianship protects research capability directly: an instrument that is calibrated on schedule and handed on cleanly serves every project that depends on it, not just the one that happened to be running when it was last checked. The University's research strategy already depends, in practice, on this kind of custody working quietly in the background; this priority simply makes that dependency visible, named, and reviewable rather than trusting it to survive the next round of staff turnover by luck.



What we'll do

1. Assign a named custodian to every item of shared research equipment and every actively maintained dataset, published on the research-infrastructure register alongside the Stewardship Register.
2. Require an annual custodianship attestation, renewed or formally reassigned, with a documented succession protocol triggered the moment a custodian departs.
3. Route every custodian-reported fault directly into the relevant lab's maintenance queue, closing the loop between a report and its resolution.
4. Publish a lightweight custodianship handbook for each equipment category — calibration cadence, fault-reporting steps, succession checklist — so a new custodian inherits a procedure, not just a name.

How we'll know

- 100% of shared research equipment carries an active, attested custodian by 2029.
- Average custodian tenure at handover exceeds eighteen months, with a documented successor named within a fortnight of any departure.
- Equipment fault-to-resolution time falls year-on-year for the remainder of the plan.
- Every equipment category carries a published handbook, reviewed at each custodianship handover without exception.

A Connected and Accountable Campus

Why this matters

Committee minutes and process action items too often close without anyone clearly responsible for carrying them forward, and a good decision that dissolves into an unowned action item is functionally indistinguishable from a decision never taken at all. Naming an owner at the point of minuting connects governance to delivery, and connecting the Stewardship Register to the Living Dashboard means an asset's steward and its live status are always read from the same published record. A campus that is well connected on paper — a register here, a dashboard there, a committee structure that maps neatly onto both — is only actually accountable if the same name can be followed from one system to the next without a gap.

What we'll do

1. Require every committee and working-group action item to carry a named owner and a review date at the point it is minuted, with no "for information" placeholder standing in for an owner.
2. Publish an escalation ladder naming who inherits an action when its owner is unavailable, rather than leaving it to whoever next reads the minutes.
3. Integrate the Stewardship Register with the Living Dashboard so an asset's steward and its live status sit on the one published record.
4. Review every standing committee's terms of reference to confirm it names an owner for each of its recurring outputs, not only for one-off decisions.

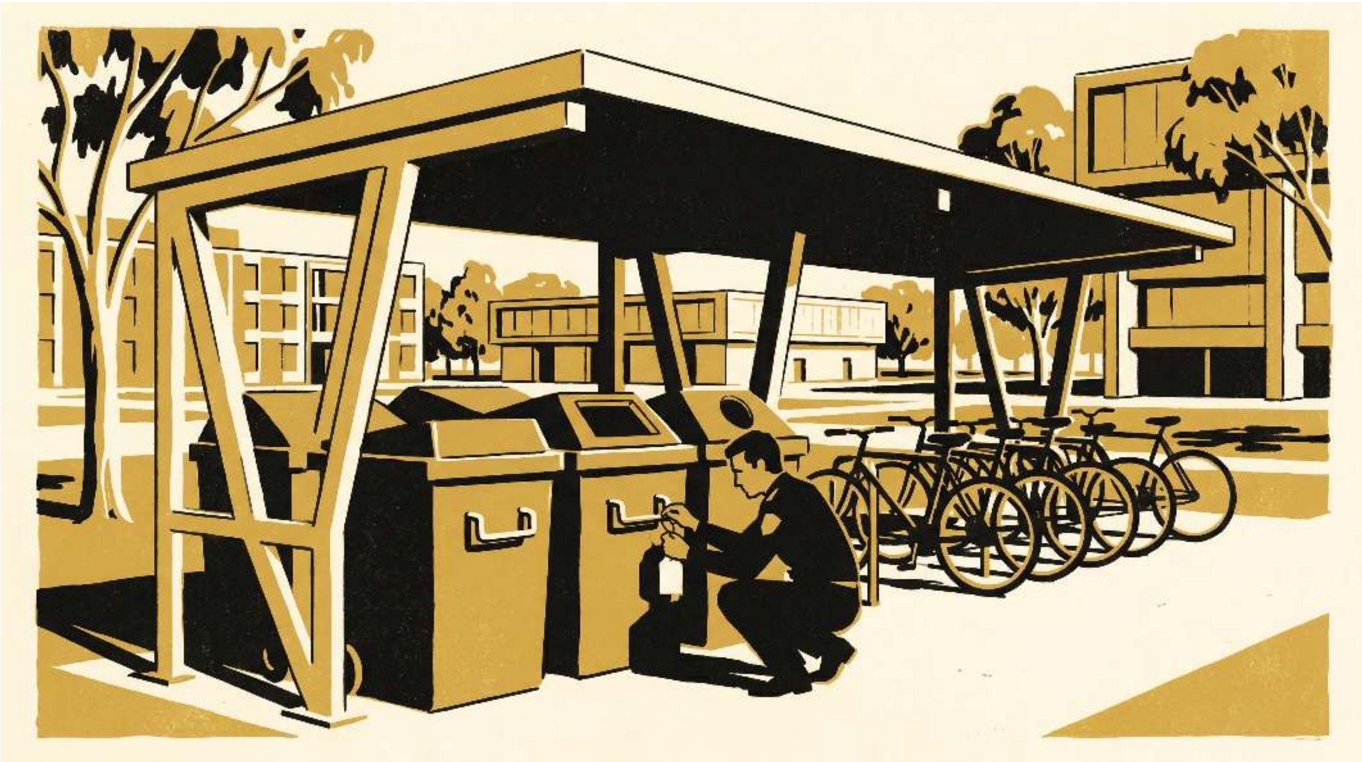
How we'll know

- The proportion of action items closed by their originally assigned owner exceeds 90% every year of the plan.
- Median time from an escalation trigger to a named successor being confirmed falls to under one week by 2029.
- 100% of Living Dashboard entries carry a visible, linked steward by the close of the plan period.
- Every standing committee's terms of reference names an owner for each recurring output by the end of 2028.

Sustainable Foundations

Why this matters

Environmental and facilities commitments depend on someone actually maintaining what has been installed — compost points, recycling stations, shared-transport infrastructure — and an unnamed "Facilities will handle it" framing has let some of this quietly lapse without ever registering as a failure anyone owned. A sustainability commitment that nobody is individually accountable for delivering is, in practice, an aspiration rather than a foundation, and this priority is what turns it back into the latter.



What we'll do

1. Name a building warden accountable for every recycling, compost, and shared-transport point on campus, published alongside the Stewardship Register.

2. Commission an annual environmental stewardship review naming which warden is accountable for each finding, with corrective actions logged against that same name.
3. Extend named accountability to every fire-safety and egress asset, so a missed check has a name attached to it rather than a rostered function.
4. Publish an annual Sustainable Foundations summary alongside the Named Ownership Report, naming coverage by building and flagging any point still without a warden.

How we'll know

- 100% of recycling, compost, and shared-transport points carry a named warden by 2027.
- Unassigned-asset incident reports — a fault logged with no accountable contact — fall to zero by 2029, sustained through the remainder of the plan.
- Warden turnover is tracked, and a successor is named within a fortnight of any departure, every time.
- The annual Sustainable Foundations summary is published on schedule every year of the plan, with no building omitted.

Delivering this plan

Named ownership will be built in four phases running contiguously across the plan period, deliberately sequenced so that the smallest, most visible assets are named first — proving the model works before it is asked to carry anything more consequential.

Establish, 2026 — the University stands up the Stewardship Register and names its first wave of stewards, beginning with common-area equipment: loaner items, noticeboards, and shared kitchenette appliances across every building. Induction materials are drafted alongside the first wave, so early stewards are never left to work out the role from the register entry alone.

Build, 2027-28 — named custodianship extends to shared research equipment and actively maintained datasets; committee action items begin closing to a named owner and a review date as standard practice; the escalation ladder is published and tested against its first real vacancy. The first annual Named Ownership Report goes to the Executive at the close of this phase, giving the University its first real read on whether the model is holding.

Embed, 2029-30 — the Stewardship Register and the Living Dashboard are integrated into a single published record; facilities and environmental warden coverage reaches its full extent; "shared responsibility" is formally retired from every asset description that still carries it. By the close of this phase, a member of the

University community should be unable to find a shared asset, process, or resource without a name attached to it.

Renew, 2031 — every named steward across the University is re-attested, the Register is refreshed end to end, and the named-ownership model is reviewed in full against the measures set out in this plan, ahead of the University's next planning cycle. Renewal is treated as routine rather than exceptional: a model built to outlast any one steward's tenure should be able to survive its own first full turnover without visible strain.

Accountability and review

The University Council retains standing oversight of the Stewardship Register, receiving it as a fixed agenda item at each of its ordinary meetings across the plan period. The Executive receives an annual Named Ownership Report, tabling Register coverage, custodian tenure, and escalation performance against the measures in this plan.

The Review Cadence Observatory monitors the Register's own review cycle, flagging any steward entry whose due date has passed unattested, and the Indicator Commons holds the shared indicators this plan reports against, consistent with the University's existing evaluation-ecosystem practice. No new committee is created to hold this work; it is carried by the governance structures the University already has, with one addition — every one of those structures will now be able to say, for anything within its remit, who specifically is accountable for it.

Each School retains responsibility for naming stewards and custodians within its own remit; the Register's role is to hold those names in one place and make the absence of one impossible to overlook. Where a School disagrees with a finding of the Review Cadence Observatory, the matter is escalated to the Executive rather than resolved informally, so that a disputed entry is settled on the record and not simply left blank until someone remembers to revisit it.

The decade ahead

By 2031, an umbrella returned late to its stand, a fault logged against a piece of shared equipment, and an action item minuted in a committee room will each resolve to the same thing: a name, published, and checkable. None of these are large ambitions taken alone. Taken together, across everything the University holds, they close the distance between what this institution says it is accountable for and what it can actually show, on the day someone asks, that it is.

This is not, in the end, a plan about umbrellas, or noticeboards, or compost bins. It is a plan about what an institution is willing to be held to, and whether it can say so in one word: a name. Slop University intends, by the close of this plan, to be able to say it every time.

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